

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, windy, cooler, rain at times, high 59. **Tonight**, breezy, colder, clearing, low 32. **Tomorrow**, breezy, cool, morning sun, afternoon clouds, high 47. Weather map, Page A20.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



At a demonstration in Tehran, health care workers held photos of some students killed in the Feb. 28 strike on an elementary school.

Leaders to Tap Oil Reserves as Attacks Hinder Shipping

400 Million Barrels, a Record, Are Set to Be Released

This article is by **Rebecca F. Elliott, Abdi Latif Dahir, Eric Schmitt and Michael Levenson.**

World leaders raced on Wednesday to shore up the global oil supply as the war in the Middle East and retaliatory attacks by Iran threatened to choke off the Strait of Hormuz, a vital passage for oil tankers. The threat was punctuated when three ships in or near the strait were damaged by strikes.

Hours later, the International Energy Agency said that its 32 member countries — which include Britain, Germany, Japan and the United States — would release 400 million barrels of oil from their strategic reserves, the most ever and the first such coordinated action since 2022, after Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Fatih Birol, the agency’s executive director, did not say when the countries would begin releasing the oil, which would be enough to meet about four days’ worth of global demand. The coordinated effort came as high oil prices have driven up costs for consumers, with gas prices in the United States rising for the 11th straight day on Wednesday to a national average of \$3.58 a gallon.

“This is a major action aiming to alleviate the immediate impacts of the disruption in markets,” Mr. Birol said in Paris, where the International Energy Agency, which was created in 1974 to help prevent price shocks, is based. “But to be clear, the most important thing for a return to stable flows of oil and gas is the resumption of transit through the Strait of Hormuz.”

The move by the International Energy Agency came as Israel and the United States launched more attacks against Iran and the



Iran appeared to take responsibility for a strike on a Thai bulk carrier. Two other ships in or near the Strait of Hormuz were also hit.



Sisters playing near their family’s tent in Beirut, Lebanon. Officials in the nation said over 800,000 people had been displaced.

Israeli military said on Wednesday evening that it had begun a “wave of extensive strikes” against what it described as Hezbollah infrastructure in the southern outskirts of Beirut, the Lebanese capital.

Explosions echoed across the city as night fell, rattling windows and sending thick plumes of acrid smoke rising over the capital.

Earlier, residents of central Beirut’s densely populated Aisha

Bakkar district awoke to explosions after Israeli strikes hit an apartment building in the area. At least four people were wounded, the Lebanese health ministry said. Parts of the multistory building were blasted apart, sending debris, twisted rebar and rubble crashing onto cars in the street.

“I woke up and found myself on the floor,” said Ahmad Ballout, 67, an English teacher who lives in an

Trump and Advisers Underestimated Iran’s Response

This article is by **Mark Mazzetti, Tyler Pager and Edward Wong.**

WASHINGTON — On Feb. 18, as President Trump weighed whether to launch military attacks on Iran, Chris Wright, the energy secretary, told an interviewer he was not concerned that the looming war might disrupt oil supplies in the Middle East and wreak havoc in energy markets.

Even during the Israeli and U.S. strikes against Iran last June, Mr. Wright said, there had been little disruption in the markets. “Oil prices blipped up and then went back down,” he said. Some of Mr. Trump’s other advisers shared similar views in private, dismissing warnings that — the second time around — Iran might wage economic warfare by closing shipping lanes carrying roughly 20 percent of the world’s oil supply.

The extent of that miscalculation was laid bare in recent days, as Iran threatened to fire at commercial oil tankers transiting the Strait of Hormuz, the strategic choke point through which all ships must pass on their way out of the Persian Gulf. In response to the Iranian threats, commercial shipping has come to a standstill in the Gulf, oil prices have spiked, and the Trump administration has scrambled to find ways to tamp down an economic crisis that has pushed gasoline prices higher for Americans.

The episode is emblematic of how much Mr. Trump and his advisers misjudged how Iran would respond to a conflict that the government in Tehran sees as an existential threat. Iran has re-

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OIL A plan to release 400 million barrels from world reserves did little to calm the market. PAGE B1

U.S. IS RESPONSIBLE IN SCHOOL STRIKE, EARLY REVIEW SAYS

Military Plan Relied on Outdated Data, Killing Scores of Children in Iran

This article is by **Julian E. Barnes, Eric Schmitt, Tyler Pager, Malachy Browne and Helene Cooper.**

WASHINGTON — An ongoing military investigation has determined that the United States is responsible for a deadly Tomahawk missile strike on an Iranian elementary school, according to U.S. officials and others familiar with the preliminary findings.

The Feb. 28 strike on the Shajarah Tayyebbeh elementary school building was the result of a targeting mistake by the U.S. military, which was conducting strikes on an adjacent Iranian base of which the school building was formerly a part, the preliminary investigation found. Officers at U.S. Central Command created the target coordinates for the strike using outdated data provided by the Defense Intelligence Agency, people briefed on the investigation said.

Officials emphasized that the findings are preliminary and that there are important unanswered questions about why the outdated information had not been double checked.

Striking a school full of children is sure to be recorded as one of the most devastating single military errors in recent decades. Iranian officials have said the death toll was at least 175 people, most of them children.

While the overall finding was largely expected — the United

States is the only country involved in the conflict that uses Tomahawk missiles — it has already cast a shadow on the U.S. military operation in Iran.

President Trump’s attempts to sidestep the blame for the strike have also already complicated the inquiry, leaving officials who have reviewed the findings expressing unease. The people interviewed for this story spoke on the condition of anonymity, citing the sensitive nature of the ongoing investigation and Mr. Trump’s assertion at one point that Iran, not the United States, was responsible.

“As The New York Times acknowledges in its own reporting, the investigation is still ongoing,” Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, said in a statement.

Asked about this article as he left the White House on Wednesday for a trip to promote his economic agenda in Ohio and Kentucky, Mr. Trump replied, “I don’t know about that.”

People briefed on the investigation said many questions were yet to be answered around why outdated information was used and who failed to verify the data.

Still, the error has not surprised current and former officials.

The school, in the town of Minab, is on the same block as buildings used by Iran’s Islamic

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Changes at Shajarah Tayyebbeh School

Satellite images reviewed by The Times showed that watchtowers that once stood near the school building had been removed. Three entrances were added, and play areas, including a sports field, were painted on asphalt. The walls were painted blue and pink.



Sources: Maxar, via Google Earth; CNES / Airbus, via Google Earth. THE NEW YORK TIMES

Starmer Named Ally of Epstein As an Envoy Despite Warnings

By **MICHAEL D. SHEAR**

LONDON — Prime Minister Keir Starmer of Britain was warned that making Peter Mandelson his ambassador to the United States carried “general reputational risk” because of Mr. Mandelson’s ties to the convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, according to documents released on Wednesday by the British government.

The prime minister made the appointment anyway, announcing that he was “delighted” with his decision and that Mr. Mandelson would “bring unrivaled experi-

ence to the role and take our partnership from strength to strength.”

That announcement came despite expressions of caution from some of his aides. In a due diligence checklist provided to Mr. Starmer by his vetting team on Dec. 11, 2024, officials highlighted details that were publicly known about the close relationship between Mr. Mandelson and Mr. Epstein.

“After Epstein was first convicted of procuring an underage

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Battered in the Midwest and South

Northern Illinois, above, and northwest Indiana bore the brunt of a deadly storm that spawned up to a dozen tornadoes. PAGE A21.

Ultrawealthy Flood Campaigns With Cash, Steering Elections

By **MIKE BAKER and STEVEN RICH**

Several years ago, before he was elected as a U.S. senator from Montana, Tim Sheehy was running an aerial firefighting business that was struggling to secure clients and desperately hunting for cash to build out a fleet of aircraft.

Then he found a lifeline: As Mr. Sheehy has told the story over the years, Stephen Schwarzman, the billionaire chairman of the private equity group Blackstone, helped steer a \$150 million investment from his company to Mr. Sheehy’s.

BILLIONAIRE BOOM
Influencing Politics

Both Mr. Schwarzman and Mr. Sheehy came out winners. Blackstone nearly doubled its investment by cashing in many of its shares a few years later, even as the firefighting company continued to struggle. Mr. Sheehy collected multimillion-dollar bonuses that helped him seed his Republican Senate campaign in 2024.

It was an uphill race against a popular, three-term Democratic

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Market Flashes Warning Signs

The immense influence that Big Tech companies exert over the S&P 500 has raised alarms: If a few falter, the whole economy takes a hit. PAGE B1

SPORTS B9-12

They Can’t Sweep Away Errors

The art of the perfect curling shot in the Paralympics, where athletes rely on 7-foot sticks and their own aim, with no brooms to aid the stones’ paths. PAGE B9

ARTS C1-8

Cold Doesn’t Faze Festival

In the Hudson Valley town of Chatham, N.Y., a weeklong event called the Dark took over theaters, bars, a church, a library, and even a sauna. PAGE C1

THURSDAY STYLES D1-8

Still Working the Runway

J. Alexander, or Miss J, who became a star teaching models how to strut, discusses how a stroke has affected his perceptions of the catwalk. PAGE D6

OPINION A22-23

Kate Brannen

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